continued to support Naga and Mizo rebels in the northeast. They seemed to be more trustworthy than the unruly Indian Maoists.

While the Chinese were determined to find and support proxies who could fight the war for them in India, the Indians had changed their attitude towards the Tibetan refugees—and the Tibetan resistance—after the 1962 War. Although relations between India and the Soviet Union became close and cordial in the 1960s, this did not prevent India's security services from cooperating with the CIA, which had provided clandestine support for the Tibetan resistance since the 1950s. After the 1962 War, the Tibetan guerrillas who had been trained at Camp Hale in Colorado were transferred to India where, according to the Tibetan historian Tsering Shakya, 'the Indians had established a secret Tibetan Army base near Dehra Dun at Chakrata, more commonly known to the Tibetans as Unit Twenty-Two'.[79] More than 12,000 Tibetans were brought to Chakrata, where many of them underwent military training. The Dalai Lama's government in exile at McLeodganj in the hills above Dharamsala provided leadership for the struggle, which, however, in the end amounted to more of an intelligence gathering expedition than an outright armed struggle against the Chinese occupation of Tibet.

The actual forward base for the resistance was not at the relatively short-lived camp in India but in Mustang, in a remote corner of Tibet, adjacent to the frontier. Mustang, ruled by a local feudal lord and sometimes described as a 'semi-independent Tibetan kingdom' inside Nepal, was surrounded on three sides by Chinese-occupied Tibet. It was sufficiently difficult to access by land, making it easy for the CIA to keep their operations secret. Soldiers from the regular Royal Nepalese Army also guarded all the mountain trails and passes leading into the area. Weapons and other supplies were airdropped from C-130 transport planes that had flown from Okinawa and through the Indian air space, and had been refuelled at Takhli airbase in Thailand. Before the 1962 War, the American planes dropping supplies and getting guerrillas in and out of Tibet had used obscure airfields in East Pakistan and then flown only across the narrow corridor of Indian territory between Nepal and Bhutan.

From a military point of view, though, Mustang was a bad choice for a rebel base. There were almost no villages on the barren and desolate Tibetan side of the border where the rebels could get food and other supplies, or organize an uprising against the Chinese. Then, in January